Year 5 English | The Unexpected Message

Learn and notice | Write an opening that raises a useful question

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Name: _____ Date: _____

Learning intention

I can introduce a character and situation, then create a question that makes the reader want to continue.

Model opening: The Note in the Book

A folded note slipped from the library book as Priya opened it. Three words were written across the paper: Check the clock.

She glanced at the clock above the librarian's desk. Its hands had stopped at twelve, although the bell had just rung for afternoon reading. Priya turned the note over. On the back, someone had drawn a tiny blue door.

There was a blue door beside the clock. Yesterday it had been locked. Today, it stood slightly open.

Writing detective

1. What do we learn about Priya and her situation?
2. Which details create a question for the reader?
3. What could happen next that uses an existing clue?

Notice and explain

A. One day a person got a message. It was strange.
B. A folded note slipped from Priya's library book: Check the clock.
Which gives the reader a clearer situation and a more specific question? Explain.

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Year 5 English | The Unexpected Message

Think and plan | Write an opening that raises a useful question

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Your writing task

Write The Message Nobody Expected for classmates. Create an opening that draws the reader in, develop connected events and give a satisfying ending. The model is an opening only; your story needs an ending.

Character and situation

Who receives your message? Where are they? What are they already doing?

Unexpected message

What does it say or show? Why does it matter to this character?

A useful clue

Choose one specific detail that can matter later. Avoid unrelated mysteries.

Middle events

How does the character respond? What consequence follows?

Ending and payoff

How will the ending explain or use your opening clue?

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Write your draft | Use your own ideas

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Your turn

Write The Message Nobody Expected for classmates. Create an opening that draws the reader in, develop connected events and give a satisfying ending. The model is an opening only; your story needs an ending. Useful words: folded, glanced, instruction, hesitated, discovered. Use words only when they fit.

My writing

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Edit and improve | Show what changed

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Read your draft aloud

[ ] My opening introduces a character and situation.
[ ] The message creates a relevant question.
[ ] Later events use the opening clue.
[ ] My ending gives the reader a useful payoff.

One focused improvement

Before: A boy got a strange message.
After: As Eli packed his cricket bag, his phone lit up: Bring the old scorebook.
Improve your opening with a precise situation and one clue. Keep it consistent with the rest of the story.

My before-and-after revision

Original sentence(s):

Improved version:

Explain your change

My change helps the reader because _____

Final writing detective check

[ ] I checked capitals, punctuation and spelling.
[ ] I grouped related ideas in paragraphs where useful.
[ ] I can explain one meaningful change.

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Teacher and parent guide | Answers and teaching support

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Teaching sequence

Use two sessions: read/discuss/plan (about 20–25 minutes), then write/revise (about 20–30 minutes). Adjust to the learner. Rehearse orally before writing; supply extra paper if needed. Models are teaching examples, not scripts to memorise.

Answers and acceptable alternatives

Priya is in a library opening a book. The instruction, stopped clock and blue door create questions about their connection. Accept continuations that use one of those clues; the writer does not need to reveal everything immediately.
Notice task: B names the character, places the message in a specific situation and gives a clue. A is vague. Either opening style could be developed, but B supplies more useful detail here.

Support, challenge and coaching

Support: Use an ordinary message with an unexpected instruction. Rehearse who receives it, where and why it matters.
Challenge: Plant a clue whose meaning becomes clear at the ending. Avoid adding mysteries you never resolve.
Ask: What question will your reader ask? Where does your story answer it?

Record learning and check transfer

For each page 4 skill, record Not yet / With support / Independently. Give one specific next step and let the child make the change. Record adult prompting or scribing.
Later prompt: The Unexpected Parcel. Hide the model and check whether the target skill transfers. These are classroom practice criteria, not NAPLAN scores.

Curriculum and preparation scope

Supports selected aspects of AC9E5LY06: developing ideas, organising and linking paragraphs, precise vocabulary and text connectives. Guided skill practice for NAPLAN preparation; not an official test or score prediction.
Sources: ACARA v9 Year 5 “Informative text: Bushfires”; nap.edu.au narrative and persuasive writing guides.

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